Halley's Comet Leaves a Trail of Shooting Stars

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You do not have to wait for Halley's **Comet** to come back to see shooting stars from it. This week, Earth passed through a trail of dust the **comet** left behind, and the tiny bits made the Orionid **meteor shower**.

On Oct. 21, photographer Tim McCollum took a special picture above Toccoa, Georgia. Between 3 and 4 in the morning, he caught three bright meteors in the sky. The shooting stars seem to fly out from one point near Betelgeuse, a **red giant star** in Orion. Halley's **Comet** is now more than 3 billion miles away, but the dust it shed still glows brightly when it hits our air.

The photo also shows Orion's Belt, the Orion **Nebula** and the **Milky Way**. McCollum used a **star tracker** and joined many photos into one picture.

Missed it? The shower lasts until Nov. 7, so you may still spot a shooting star on a clear night.

Word Treasure

comet -- A ball of ice and dust that travels around the Sun and can grow a glowing tail.

meteor shower -- A time when many shooting stars streak across the sky over a few nights.

red giant star -- A very large, old star that has swelled up and glows red.

Nebula -- A huge cloud of gas and dust in space where new stars can form.

Milky Way -- The galaxy we live in, which looks like a pale band of light across the night sky.

star tracker -- A device that slowly moves a camera so it follows the stars as Earth turns.

Background you need

Halley's Comet is a famous ball of ice and dust that journeys through space and swings past Earth only once in a long while.

As a comet travels, it sheds tiny bits of dust along its path, leaving a long trail floating in space.

When Earth passes through that trail, the dust bits burn up in our air and streak across the sky as shooting stars, and that is what a meteor shower is.

Break it down

WHO: Photographer Tim McCollum, who caught three bright meteors in one picture

WHAT: Earth passed through a trail of dust left behind by Halley's Comet, and the tiny bits made the Orionid meteor shower

WHERE: Above Toccoa, Georgia, between 3 and 4 in the morning on Oct. 21

WHY: The comet shed the dust as it traveled, and the bits still glow brightly when they hit our air, even though the comet is now more than 3 billion miles away

Why it matters

On a clear night before Nov. 7, you can step outside and watch for shooting stars made by dust from a famous comet.

Test what you remember

1. What made the Orionid meteor shower this week?

- (A) Ice falling from airplanes
- (B) Sparks from a rocket launch
- (C) Dust left behind by Halley's Comet
- (D) Pieces of the Moon breaking off

2. Who took a special picture of the meteors?

- (A) A scientist at MIT
- (B) An astronaut in space
- (C) Photographer Tim McCollum
- (D) A student with a phone

3. Where was the picture taken?

- (A) Inside a space station
- (B) From a boat on the ocean
- (C) Over a desert
- (D) Above Toccoa, Georgia

4. The shooting stars seem to fly out from one point near which star?

- (A) The North Star
- (B) The Sun
- (C) Betelgeuse
- (D) Orion's Belt

5. How did McCollum make his picture?

- (A) He used a star tracker and joined many photos into one picture
- (B) He used a telescope on a spaceship
- (C) He took one quick snapshot
- (D) He painted it from memory

6. How long does the shower last?

- (A) Until the comet comes back
- (B) All winter long
- (C) Until Nov. 7
- (D) One night only

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: D 4: C 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):